

Round Ligament Pain

Understanding a Common Pregnancy Discomfort

What Is Round Ligament Pain?

Round ligament pain is a common and **normal** part of pregnancy. Thick ligaments (called round ligaments) hold your uterus in place. As your uterus grows, these ligaments stretch and thin out. The pulling and tugging can irritate nearby nerves, causing sharp or aching pain — most often on the **right side** of the lower abdomen or pelvis.

Common Symptoms

- Sharp, sudden pain or spasm on one or both sides of the lower abdomen
- Pain triggered by quick movements — rolling over in bed, standing up, coughing, or sneezing
- A dull ache after a busy or active day
- Pain that is brief and resolves on its own

When Does It Happen?

Round ligament pain is most common during the **second trimester** (around 14–27 weeks) as the uterus is growing rapidly, but it can occur at any point during pregnancy. It typically resolves completely after delivery.

Tips for Relief

- **Change positions slowly** — avoid sudden twisting or turning
- **Rest** — lie on the opposite side of the pain with a pillow between your knees
- **Warm compress** — apply a heating pad on low or take a warm bath
- **Prenatal stretching** — gentle yoga or pelvic tilts can reduce tension
- **Supportive belt** — a maternity support band may ease ligament strain
- **Acetaminophen (Tylenol)** — safe to take as directed for persistent pain

When to Call Your Provider

Contact your provider or go to the ER if your pain is accompanied by:

- Fever, chills, or nausea / vomiting
- Pain or burning with urination
- Vaginal bleeding or unusual discharge
- Pain that is severe, constant, or worsening
- Contractions (tightening at regular intervals)
- Difficulty walking

These symptoms may indicate a urinary tract infection, preterm labor, or another condition that requires evaluation.

The good news: round ligament pain resolves completely after delivery!

This handout is for educational purposes only and does not replace medical advice. Always consult your provider with concerns.